

Treatise on Good Works

The Fifth and Sixth Commandments

The **four preceding Commandments** have their works in the **understanding**, that is, they **take a man captive**, rule him and make him subject, so that he rule not himself, approve not himself, think not highly of himself; but in humility know himself and allow himself to be led, that pride be prevented. The **following Commandments deal with the passions and lust** of men, that these also be killed.

- Can you remember the first four commandments? How do they go along with what Luther says here?
- What does he say about the next six commandments.

I. The passions of anger and revenge, of which the **Fifth Commandment** says, "**Thou shalt not kill.**" This Commandment has **one work**, which however **includes many** and **dispels many vices**, and is called **meekness**. Now this is of **two kinds**. The one has a beautiful splendor, and there is nothing back of it. This we **practice toward our friends and those who do us good** and give us pleasure with goods, honor and favor, or who do not offend us with words nor with deeds. ... Certainly, my good man, so the evil spirit also would be meek if he had his own way. Dissatisfaction and resentment overwhelm you in order that they may show you how full of anger and wickedness you are, that you may be admonished to strive after meekness and to drive out anger.

- What is the first kind of meekness that Luther describes, and is it really meekness at all?
- Is this kind of meekness good for a person who is doing business?
- What would happen to a person in business who didn't practice this kind of meekness?

The **second form of meekness** is good through and through, that which is **shown toward opponents and enemies**, does them no harm, **does not revenge itself, does not curse nor revile**, does not speak evil of them, **does not meditate evil against them**, although they had taken away goods, honor, life, friends and everything. Nay, where it is possible, it returns good for evil, speaks well of them, thinks well of them, prays for them. Of this Christ says, **Matthew v**: "Do good to them that despitefully use you. Pray for them that persecute you and revile you." And Paul, **Romans xii**: "Bless them which curse you, and by no means curse them, but do good to them."

- What do you think of the idea of not meditating on evil against a person who did you harm?
- What does the Bible say about this?

II. **Behold how this precious, excellent work has been lost among Christians**, so that nothing now everywhere prevails except strife, war, quarreling, anger, hatred, envy, back-biting, cursing, slandering, injuring, vengeance, and all manner of angry works and words; and yet, with all this, **we have our many holidays, hear masses, say our prayers, establish churches, and more such spiritual finery, which God has not commanded**. We shine resplendently and excessively, as if we were the most holy Christians there ever were. And so because of these mirrors and masks we allow God's Commandment to go to complete ruin, and no one considers or examines himself, how near or how far he be from meekness and the fulfilment of this Commandment; although God has said, that not he who does such works, but he who keeps His Commandments, shall enter into eternal life

- Luther thought the practice of Christian meekness had been lost in his day. Do you think things have improved in the last 500 years?
- What is it God hasn't commanded Christians to do that bothers Luther?

Thou shalt not commit adultery.

In **this Commandment** too a good work is commanded, which **includes much** and drives away much vice; it is called **purity, or chastity**, of which much is written and preached, and it is well known to every one, only that it is **not as carefully observed and practised as other works which are not commanded**. So ready are we to do what is not commanded and to leave undone what is commanded. We see that **the world is full of shameful works of unchastity, indecent words, tales and ditties, temptation to which is daily** increased through gluttony and drunkenness, idleness and frippery. Yet we go our way as if we were Christians; **when we have been to church, have said our little prayer, have observed the fasts and feasts, then we think our whole duty is done.**

- What does it mean that chastity is not practiced as much as other works which are not commanded by God?
- In the last five hundred years have people become more or less pure?
- People who go to church regularly may think they've done everything required to be right with God, but have they?

Now, **if no other work were commanded** but chastity alone, **we would all have enough to do** with this one; so perilous and raging a vice is unchastity. It rages in all our members: in the thoughts of our hearts, in the seeing of our eyes, in the hearing of our ears, in the words of our mouth, in the works of our hands and feet and all our body. **To control all these requires labor and effort**; and thus **the Commandments of God teach us** how great truly good works are, nay, **that it is impossible for us of our own strength to conceive a good work**, to say nothing of attempting or doing it. St. Augustine says, that **among all the conflicts of the Christian the conflict of chastity is the hardest**, for the one reason alone, that it continues daily without ceasing, and chastity seldom prevails. This all the saints have wept over and lamented, as St. Paul does, **Romans vii**: "I find in me, that is in my flesh, no good thing."

- How do the commandments show us that we need God's strength to obey them?
- Why would the good work required to obey this commandment, chastity, be considered the most difficult in obeying all the commandments?

II. If this work of chastity is to be permanent, it will **drive to many other good works**, to fasting and temperance over against gluttony and drunkenness, to watching and early rising over against laziness and excessive sleep, to work and labor over against idleness. For gluttony, drunkenness, lying late abed, loafing and being without work are weapons of unchastity, with which chastity is quickly overcome. On the other hand, the holy Apostle Paul calls fasting, watching and labor godly weapons, with which unchastity is mastered; but, as has been said above, these exercises must do no more than overcome unchastity, and not pervert nature.

Above all this, the strongest defence is prayer and the Word of God; namely, that **when evil lust stirs, a man flee to prayer, call upon God's mercy and help, read and meditate on the Gospel, and in it consider Christ's sufferings**. Thus says **Psalm cxxxvii**: "Happy shall he be, that taketh and dasheth the little ones of Babylon against the rock," that is, if the heart runs to the Lord Christ with its evil thoughts while they are yet young and just beginning; for Christ is a Rock, on which they are ground to powder and come to naught.

- When tempted to sin what can a person who believes in Christ can do?

III. In this work **a good strong faith is a great help**, more noticeably so than in almost any other; so that for this reason also **Isaiah xi. says that "faith is a girdle of the reins," that is, a guard of chastity**. For he who so lives that he looks to God for all grace, takes pleasure in spiritual purity; therefore he can so much more easily resist fleshly impurity: and **in such faith the Spirit tells him of a certainty how he shall avoid evil thoughts and everything that is repugnant to chastity**. For as the faith in divine favor lives without ceasing and works in all works, so it also does not cease its admonitions in all things that are pleasing to God or displease Him; as **St. John says in his Epistle**: "Ye need not that any man teach you: for the divine anointing, that is, the Spirit of God, teacheth you of all things."

- How can faith produce chastity?
- How important is chastity?